

BURNERS

A little good, a little bad, a little of both.

Fast, lethal sword-and-sorcerie in the Dragon Isles. Fire makes it good.

v0.5

What Is a Burner?

Respectable folk spit the word. **Burner**: you're the drifter who blows into a harbor town on the evening tide with a sword, a spell, or a set of picks, takes the job nobody sane will touch, and is gone by the next fog, leaving behind a lighter strongbox, a heavier graveyard, and, often enough, a smoking ruin where a problem used to be. Not a soldier. Not a hero. Not exactly *honest*. A Burner.

They mean it as an insult. You wear it like a medal.

Because you are defined by one thing: **knowing which move the moment calls for**. When to stand in the press and trade blows. When to give ground and cut your losses. When to look at a thing too big to kill and simply *never draw*. Walk wide and live. And when the footing's gone and the odds have turned, when to *run*, purse be damned, and count breath as winning.

And when the job's finally done and the reckoning comes howling up the stairs behind you, you know the last move, the one that earned the name. **Leave nothing behind but smoke**. Fire settles most debts. Fire makes it good. *What do we do with witches? We burn 'em*.

Most who take up this trade don't last a season. The docks are full of would-be Burners who didn't know when to run, or drew on the wrong thing in the dark, or stayed one round too long admiring their own work. You won't become a *name* with a song sung about you by being the strongest or the deadliest. You'll become one by reading a bad bet and folding it.

You are a Burner. So is everyone at this table. You are not here to save the Dragon Isles; you are here to get in, get paid, and get out with your skin, and if the place is on fire behind you as you go, well. It usually is, after all, *"fire makes it good"*.

The rest of this book is about staying alive long enough to be a name instead of a warning.

What You Do

Say what you do: *I pick the lock*, not *I try to pick the lock*. If the plan is sound, it works. If the moment is risky, the Referee names what it costs, and you roll to pay less.

Your character is built from four **Approaches** (Sword, Craft, Heart, Sorcerie), a list of **Traits**, and **twelve equipment slots**.

Glossary

Quick definitions. Details live in the chapters below.

Character

- **When you make a character:** you start at level 1. Put that level in one Approach. Write up to four Traits. You can leave blanks and fill them in later when play hands you the name. Roll 1d6 for starting HP.
- **Trait:** a skill or quality: *lockpicking, steady under fire, knows the fens*. You tag each Trait to an Approach. Traits do not raise your Approach level. They say what you can do. Some actions need a specific Trait (like a magic school, languages, plate armor, or a complex greatsword or longbow). Use a Trait well in play and it can earn a **Signature**.
- **Approach:** one of Sword, Craft, Heart, or Sorcerie.
 - **Sword:** fighting to the death. Weapons, armor, tactics, footwork, tempo. Used in a fight, not a friendly brawl.
 - **Craft:** practical skill. Stealth, locks, tracking, sailing, survival, first aid, making and mending.
 - **Heart:** people. Persuasion, intimidation, empathy, medicine, leadership, trade, languages, friendly brawls.
 - **Sorcerie:** magic and the unseen. Spell schools, divination, binding, alchemy, ancient lore.
- **Character level:** your overall rank. You buy levels with XP (see *Experience*). Every level you gain is one level you place in an Approach, up to four more Traits, and a reroll of your HP.
- **Signature:** an asterisk on a Trait. A knack that showed up at your table. You never buy it, and it is not a spell.
- **Theme:** your name or alias and a short line on who you are. For the other players, not the mechanics.

Equipment

- **Gold pieces (gp):** all prices use traditional gold pieces.
- **Inventory slots:** twelve slots for weapons, armor, gear, and baggage. Big items (a sword, a shield, a backpack) use more than one. Anything carried in your hands outside those twelve slots costs no slots but occupies your hands.
- **Baggage:** small items can share a slot if they ride in a pouch, quiver, or satchel (1 slot). A backpack (3 slots) holds bedroll, rope, rations, and loot efficiently, but takes ten minutes to unpack.
- **Empty slots:** free space is speed. Every empty slot adds a die to your Fuel on the Initiative roll, up to four. Light kit, quick feet. Dropping something to free a slot is an action.
- **Armor class (AC):** how much your armor shaves off every hit before it reaches you. Leather is 1, gambeson 2, mail 3, plate 4–5. Most harness is open; plate is trained-only (see *Training* under *Weapons, Armor, and Shields*). See *Armor* under *Fighting*.

HP, Heat, and Wounds

- **HP:** luck and wind, not meat — **hit protection**. One d6 per character level, rolled at creation. Reroll at level-up and keep the higher of the new total or old+1. Bites come off HP first; only overflow past 0 opens a Wound. Reach **full HP** and your wounds close.
- **Heat:** your crew's shared danger gauge. How hot the *scene* is, not your hit points. Most risky actions out of combat quote a Cost against Heat. If you split the party, each group tracks its own Heat.
- **Feeding Heat:** when a risky action goes wrong, Heat usually rises (often 1–2). In a fight, blows hit HP, not Heat. Heat climbs only when the situation turns worse (alarm, reinforcements, a friend down).
- **Wound:** real injury. You take one when a blow drives you **past 0 HP**, or when harm lands where **HP cannot help**. Track **wound severity** (sum of overflow from wounding attacks). Penalties last until **full HP** (maimings excepted). See *Wounds*.
- **Wound effects:** where you were hit matters. A leg wound puts you in the dirt. A head hit narrows your sight. And so on.
- **Shock Check:** when a Wound opens, roll **2d6 + Sword vs total wound severity** or drop out of the fight. Natural 1+1 always fails; 6+6 always succeeds. See *Wounds*.

Play

- **World Turn:** ten minutes of out-of-combat time. You take one World Action.
- **Two Steps:** say what you do; if the moment is risky, the Referee names the Cost (usually Heat) and you roll to pay less.
- **Trained-only:** an action you cannot attempt without a specific Trait, whatever your Approach.
- **Approach roll:** roll 2d6 and add your Approach level. To climb a cliff with Craft 3, you roll 2d6+3.
- **Alignment:** like an Approach, but for a specific situation or bond with a patron, guild, or power. Count every relevant Trait across all your Approaches, divide by 4, round down. See *Alignment*.
- **Sweet and Spicy:** a rolled 6 is Sweet (a good twist); a rolled 1 is Spicy (a complication). These ride alongside the sum and never change it. Two 6s (a natural 12) is the perfect roll. Two 1s (a natural 2) is a fumble.

Combat

- **Roll Initiative!:** at the top of every combat round. Round 1: gather and roll your full pool (character level, weapons and shields in hand, Arcana slots declared, empty slots). Round 2+: refill one Fuel die per character level, roll those into your pool, then count. See *Fighting*.
- **Combat Round:** one minute, taken in locked Initiative order. On your turn, take one Action (attack, cast a spell, etc.). Moving and positioning come with it, part of the Action, not a separate step. Defending is not free; it burns your Fuel. Sword governs the exchange: it grants you extra attacks and a deeper pool.
- **Fuel:** the dice from your Initiative rolls, kept at their faces and spent through the fight to attack, defend, cast, and riposte. From round 2 on, Roll Initiative refills one die per character level into the pool. Remove spent Fuel dice from play, they are “burned”.
- **Initiative:** the count of your Fuel showing 3 or 4 after you Roll Initiative. The Referee locks order for that round; spending a 3 or 4 does not change who goes when until the next Roll Initiative. Ties: PCs win (players choose among themselves; a PC may act before a foe or yield).

- **Attack:** each blow costs one Fuel die; a weapon of 3+ slots wielded in two hands can add a second die. Deals damage of total Fuel die faces used. With Sword, you make an extra attack per Sword level, all paid from Fuel. A die rolling 6 is a Spark, see Fighting.
- **Defend:** commit Fuel dice to cut a blow before armor soaks the rest. Caps:
 - vs melee: 1 die; no limit if you made a melee attack this round (any foe)
 - vs missile: 1 die; 2 if you have Cover
 - vs fire: no limit for you (a Burner or creature born in fire); 1 die for others
 - vs magic: no limit A 6 is a Spark (e.g. a Riposte), except as under Cover. See Fighting.
- **Cover:** fiction that lets you spend 2 dice vs a missile when you are protected by some kind of “cover” (wall, shield, creature, etc.). Using a melee foe as Cover: if you Spark on that Defend, the shot hits them!
- **Spark:** a natural 6 on a Fuel die. On Fuel it entitles you to a second combat action: an attack, a Block, or a Stunt (defending, a Riposte). You still pay for that action from your Fuel. See Fighting.
- **Block:** spend an attack and “block!” an attack aimed at an adjacent ally, interposing yourself between them and the attack. The attack redirects to you; defend it normally. You are “taking a hit for the team”. See Fighting.
- **Stunt:** spend an attack to knock down, shove, disarm, trip, or grapple a foe instead of dealing damage or Blocking. See Fighting.
- **In the dirt:** flat on the ground — a risky place to be. **Every Fuel die you spend while in the dirt is re-rolled** — the new face is what counts (blow, Defend, cast, Block, Stunt). Rise free on your Action; if a foe presses you in melee, rising costs a die re-rolled 3+ (fail and you stay down; the die is spent either way). You may **throw yourself in the dirt** on your turn (dirty fighting — free with your Action) when the pool is trash and you need a scramble.
- **Cast (Sorcerer only):** one Action in combat; spend at least Spell Level Fuel dice and roll them. The **cast total** is the sum of those faces. On a Spark, you may spend up to Spell Level additional Fuel for extra effect. The spell’s **card taps** (or stays *in play* if lasting). You may **burn** other ready cards in the same Action to recast from discard or copy a working in play. See *Magic* and [[Burners Sorcerie]].
- **Ward (Sorcerer only):** at any time, cut a **hostile magic** attack (spell cast total, magical breath, and the like — not mundane fire alone) aimed at adjacent allies or a tight group. Commit up to your **Sorcerie Level** in Fuel dice; subtract their sum from the attack value. **Each ally then Defends normally** against what remains. No school Trait required; no card. Does not take an Action. Example: a vampire *charms* a friend — Sorcerie 1 commits 1 Fuel (face 5), cutting the cast total before the friend Defends.

Monsters

- **Monster:** an enemy, regardless of species. Its Hit Dice are its level; its HP is 5 per Hit Die plus any modifier (module AC folds into HP, or into Resistance when the creature is famous for its armor — see [[Burners Referee Guide]]). Monsters do not use PC Armor Class. In a fight it rolls Fuel like you do. A fierce or many-limbed foe makes extra attacks by its nature; a named or solo foe may take the full Wound and Shock Check rules when the scene calls for it.
 - **Damage:** the faces of the dice committed to a blow, cut by your defense and armor (PC AC) or by Resistance (monsters).
 - **Resistance:** flat damage reduction against a named kind of harm: fire, silver, blades through bone, famous armor or hide, and so on. A monster’s only per-blow soak.
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Character Creation

1. You are character level 1. Place that level in one Approach: Sword, Craft, Heart, or Sorcerie.
2. Take up to four Traits, each tagged to an Approach. You need not fill all four now; backfill the rest in play.
3. Roll 1d6 for your HP.
4. Give your character a name or alias and a short “look” so the table gets to know them.
5. Take your starting kit, then spend your purse in town.

Signatures emerge in play. You do not choose them at creation.

To pick a people to come from (Northmaren, Southmaren, Elf, Alu, Kith, and the rest), see [[Burners Ancestry]]. Each entry is a ready-made look plus a menu of Traits, gear, and the Signatures your kind grows into.

Traits

On your sheet, a Trait is a skill or a quality: arming sword, herbalism, strong, perceptive, raised in the fens. You hold up to four Traits per character level, each tagged to an Approach. A Trait does not raise that Approach; your level does. You need not claim all four at each level. A delayed Trait costs nothing, so you can fill one in whenever play hands you the name. Traits come free with your levels. You never buy them with XP.

Sample Traits by Approach:

- **Sword** — arms, armor, and the fight.
 - Skills: dagger, club, spear, axe, arming sword, mace, flail, bow, crossbow, shield, wrestling, boxing, ambush, tactics, cavalry, siege, heraldry, scouting. Trained-only: greatsword, poleax, longbow, plate armor.
 - Qualities: strong, fearless, relentless, steady, iron-willed, veteran, hard to kill, courageous, steady under fire, dragon-scarred.
- **Craft** — the practical skills of daily life.
 - Skills: lockpicking, stealth, tracking, trapping, disguise, sailing, herbalism, smithing, bowyer, fletcher, carpentry, navigation, climbing, swimming, survival, bushcraft, wood lore, hunting, first aid, appraisal, rope use. School Trait:
 - Qualities: nimble, observant, patient, resourceful, quiet, cunning, light-fingered, sure-footed, raised in the fens, knows the woods.
 - Magic Schools: *Canting* (see below)
- **Heart** — people, nerve, and presence.
 - Skills: persuasion, intimidation, deception, leadership, empathy, trading, medicine, performance, streetwise, linguistics, riding, music, stagecraft, mimicry, ventriloquism, gambling, etiquette.
 - Qualities: charming, commanding, loyal, silver-tongued, well-connected, witty, jaded, honorable, commanding voice, lucky.
 - Languages: Northmaren, Southmaren, Eldarin, ... (see below)
- **Sorcerie** — the unseen, and the schools that open it.
 - Qualities: perceptive, studious, second-sight, ancient-blooded, learned, haunted, witch-blood, marsh-lore, rune-wise, bookish.
 - Arts (not schools): divination, alchemy, binding, ancient lore — learned as Traits or from books, as the table prefers.
 - Magic Schools: *Sorcerie*, *Vitae*, *Elementale*, *Thaumaturgy*, *Illusione*, *Umbrakala*, *Necromantia*, *Canting* (see below)

Languages (Heart)

Common tongues:

You've heard at least enough of all three trade tongues ("common tongues") to get by in daily communication; you can talk to innkeepers, buy gear from a shop, etc. Most Eldar and goblins in the wilds can do the same. A Trait in a trade tongue makes you fluent and literate in it — fit for courts, treaties, and books. Your Heart level determines your overall oratory and literary prowess.

- **Northmaren** — (Northman, Norn) the north: Alglonds, Lyonese, Kith lands, and the river kingdoms.
- **Southmaren** (Harnendorian, Harn) — the south and the seas; the trading tongue most nations use.
- **Eldarin** (the Elder Tongue) — old civilizations and the Eldar; nobles and diplomats often learn it.

When taking a Trait in a trade tongue, you can choose specific dialect: Alornean, Kith, Lothian, Avathar, Aquilan street cant, Ashenrise street cant, etc. In Eldarin dialects correspond to ancestry and region: Ithilrhi, Baal, Dwur, Alu, etc.

Other languages will be unfamiliar to you unless you have a Trait; they are trained-only.

Trained Only

A Trait can gate a thing: without that Trait you cannot attempt it. Magic schools work this way (no Trait in the school, no reading or casting it). So do complicated arms and armor; *Training* under *Weapons*, *Armor*, and *Shields*.

Magic Schools (Sorcerie)

Magic schools are Sorcerie Traits, and trained-only. Hold the Trait and the school is open; without it you cannot read or cast that tradition. Spells inside an open school are still learned from books. The eight schools:

- **Sorcerie** — the common craft (raw grammar of magic). No Trait needed; being a Sorcerer is enough.
- **Vitae** — life, growth, harmony (Elves).
- **Elementale** — fire, weather, dragon-magic (Baal).
- **Thaumaturgy** — force, mechanisms, engineering magic (Dwur).
- **Illusione** — perception, thought, dreams (Belerions).
- **Umbrakala** — shadows, thresholds, paths between (Alu).
- **Necromantia** — death, spirits, decay (Avathars).
- **Canting** — the Darkman's secret hedge-magic. Tags to **Craft**, not Sorcerie. Its workings ride the local street dialect — flash paper, marks, patter — but most who speak that cant never cast a card.

Starting Gear

You begin carrying the clothes on your back and a backpack. You also have a small knife, coin purse, and a firestarter somewhere on your person.

Your backpack takes 3 slots and contains: bedroll, waterskin, fifty feet of rope, one week rations, and a tinder box. You can move any of those items to your main inventory slots, but keeping it as a backpack means you can free up 3 slots by dropping it.

You may also have gear and coin from your Approach:

Approach	Gold	Comes with
Sword (Veteran)	100 gp	nothing extra (your coin <i>is</i> your kit: buy arms, armor, a shield)
Heart (Boss)	80 gp	one henchman : fills your first Heart slot (see <i>Henchmen</i> under <i>The Boss</i>); basic gear, keep and a share of the take
Craft (Journeyman)	60 gp	

Approach	Gold	Comes with
		choice of one “tool of the trade” based on one of your Traits, such as a hunting bow with a quiver of arrows, wood ax, blacksmith’s hammer, etc.
Sorcerie (Sorcerer)	40 gp	7 physical + 5 Arcana slots (locked until first sleep); personal spellbook with <i>Read Magic</i> and four other 1st-level spells (known); hand of 5 — all five ready

Veterans start as outfitted soldiers; Bosses as moneyed leaders rich in people; Journeymen as scrappy woodsmen poor in coin but woods-ready; Sorcerers as folk who spent nearly everything becoming mages. You earn legendary gear in play.

Spend your gold in town from the tables below; everything you carry ready takes an item slot, and whatever you don’t spend is yours to keep. A few sample buys:

- **Veteran** (Sword, 100 gp): a gambeson (AC 2) 30, arming sword 10, heater shield 6, for 46 gp with coin to spare. Every blow shaved by 2, a shield adding dice to the Initiative roll and Cover vs missiles. Chain mail (40) comes next; plate wants training; field and full plate are rare fitted harness.
- **Boss** (Heart, 80 gp): a spear 3, leather armor (AC 1) 20, and coin held to outfit or bankroll the henchman. A leader spends on their people.
- **Journeyman** (Craft, 60 gp + free bow & pole): thieves’ tools 25, leather armor (AC 1) 20, for 45 gp; light, mobile, bow already in hand.
- **Sorcerer** (Sorcerie, 40 gp + kit): leather armor (AC 1) 20 and oddments (a flask of oil, chalk for ritual circles, a spare dagger). The magic is already yours.

The Starting Sorcerer

A Sorcerer’s craft comes with a kit (the fruit of your apprenticeship). That is why your starting purse (40 gp) is so much lighter than a Veteran’s: you already spent most of it becoming a mage. Your kit is:

- **7 physical slots + 5 Arcana slots** — declare the split at creation; you may not re-split until your first 8-hour sleep. Arcana slots set your **hand size** (5) and hold **Wizard Drip** only — wand, staff, rod, orb, crystal, ring, amulet, mask, robes, hat, at each item’s full slot cost. Never armor, shields, or war kit. See *Arcana Slots* on [[Burners Sorcerie]].
- A **spellbook** in a **scrivener’s satchel** (book, ink pot, quill, loose-leaf paper): ***Read Magic*** plus **four other 1st-level spells** from your school, all known. The Referee picks, rolls, lets you choose, or works with you. Plain ink records Facts free; *reagent inks* that fix a working into the book are a separate cost (see *Spellbooks* on [[Burners Sorcerie]]).
- Your **hand is all five** known spells — ready to cast. Count them on your fingers.

Two of your school’s six 1st-level spells are **not** in your book. Those, deeper spells, other schools, and found drip are your hunt. *Read Magic* and readable sources (OSE) let you memorize from a found book while you carry it. Moving a spell into your book costs **100 gp × its level** and destroys the source page. See [[Burners Sorcerie]].

A **Canting Journeyman** on the Canting road also starts **7 + 5 kicks**, but with **no spells** and an empty hand until they learn Canting in play.

Weapons, Armor, and Shields

A weapon's **slots** are the dice it throws on your Initiative roll and the space it fills. A two-hander throws more but leaves no hand for a shield. A shield's slots are dice too, and a raised shield can count as **Cover** vs missiles. You wear armor, not throw it: its **AC** soaks every blow on the way in. This is the play list. Full prices and oddments are in [[Burners Equipment]]. A fuller catalog of arms is in [[Burners Arms and Armor]].

Weapon	Slots	Cost (gp)	
Dagger	1	3	can be thrown
Club	1	3	
Sling	1	2	ranged
Small ax	2	4	can be thrown
Mace (incl. war hammer)	2	5	
Arming sword	2	10	
Short bow / hunting bow	2	25	ranged, two-handed
Spear	3	3	can be thrown
Longsword	3	15	two-handed
Longbow	3	40	ranged, two-handed
Crossbow	3	30	ranged, two-handed
Battle axe	4	7	two-handed
Greatsword	4	15	two-handed
Halberd / pole arm	5	7	two-handed

Armor: AC soaks every hit on the way in, one number by the make of the armor. Full prices are in [[Burners Equipment]].

Armor	AC	Slots	Cost (gp)
Leather	1	2	20
Gambeson	2	4	30
Chain mail	3	6	40
Plate mail	4	8	60
Field plate	4	5	2,000
Full plate	5	7	4,000

Shields: a shield's slots are dice on the Initiative roll; a raised shield can count as Cover vs missiles (2 dice on that Defend).

Shield	Slots	Cost (gp)
Buckler	2	3
Heater	3	6
Rotella	4	9
Kite	4	12
Tower	5	15

Training

Most kit is open. Strap on leather or mail, pick up a spear or an arming sword, hold a heater: you get the AC, the slots, and the blows.

Some kit is **trained-only**. Without a Trait for it, you cannot use it in a fight (no AC from that harness, no Initiative dice from that weapon or shield, no blows with it). Examples:

- **Plate:** plate mail, field plate, full plate (*plate armor*)
- **Greatsword**
- **Poleax** or **halberd**
- **Longbow**

Chain mail stays open. It is heavy and awkward, but it is not a harness you have to learn the way plate is.

Enchanted kit and the extra die are separate: see *Enchanted Arms and Armor*.

Experience

You buy character level from the XP table below. You never buy Traits, Signatures, or spell learning with XP. You earn XP from:

- **Monsters:** award XP by Hit Dice when a foe is overcome (killed, routed, or otherwise neutralized as treasure). A 1 HD skeleton is 10 XP; a ~4 HD boss is 125. Split the award among your crew as you prefer; you usually divide evenly. The Referee has the full Hit Dice table.
- **Treasure: 1 XP per 1 gp** of coins, gems, and jewelry **recovered to safety**, banked in town, not merely pocketed in the delve. Loot you cannot haul home is not loot yet. Goods, art objects, and equipment count at their sale value when sold. The Referee sets the number once.

Magic items grant no XP.

When you spend it. XP banks as you earn it. You buy a character level only in civilization: a safe town, haven, or other place where you can train and rest. Mid-delve rank-ups do not happen. Rare emergencies (a vision at a Hallow, a patron's gift on the road) are the Referee's call, not the rule.

Exploration (optional). The Referee may award a small XP crumb for a wilderness hex newly mapped or a dungeon room meaningfully explored: enough to notice, not enough to replace treasure. Tune the number to your table's pace; there is no fixed award.

Henchmen (Boss only). When XP is awarded, each of your **henchmen** who delved with you and survived splits **half of your own award**. That is bonus XP, not taken from you or the rest of the crew. One henchman on the job earns 50% of what you earned. Two henchmen present split that half between them (25% of your award each). Track henchman XP on a simple line; it feeds the trainee path (see *The Boss, henchmen and command*). Paid hirelings earn no XP.

You earn by overcoming monsters and hauling treasure home.

Approach Level

Your character level is bought with XP from one table. Every level you gain is a single point you place in an Approach, so your Approach levels always sum to your character level. At 4th level you might be Sword 3 and Sorcerie 1, or Sword 2 with Craft 1 and Heart 1, however your play has shaped you. You place each point as you level and do not move the ones already set.

Character level	XP
1	0

Character level	XP
2	2,000
3	4,000
4	8,000
5	16,000
6	32,000
7	64,000
8	120,000

Your roll is 2d6 plus your Approach level. With no level in that Approach you are Approach 0: you still roll 2d6, just without a bonus. That missing bonus is the whole disadvantage. You can still attempt things at Approach 0, but that Approach's trained advantages stay locked until you reach level 1. One point is the line between a townsman and a practitioner.

Titles

When you reach level 1 in an Approach, you earn its title. The title turns on that Approach's trained advantages. Below level 1 you have no title there and get none of them.

Approach	Title	Turns on
Sword	Veteran	extra attacks
Sorcerie	Sorcerer	cast from your hand; Arcana slots and wizard drip; read magic
Craft	Journeyman	reduce party-wide travel, weather, and survival costs by your Craft level
Heart	Boss	henchman slots (one per Heart level), Morale Check for the company, bonus XP for henchmen who delved with you

The Journeyman's craft (Craft 1+). As a Veteran you rule the melee. As a Journeyman you rule the journey. Your Craft level reduces party-wide costs from travel, weather, and survival: cold, heat, hunger, thirst, exhaustion, forced marches, rough terrain, getting lost. When the Referee quotes such a cost, subtract your Craft level from it for everyone you are guiding. Often that drops the cost low enough that the Referee waives the roll. Example: the biting cold rain adds 6 Heat, and you are a Journeyman with Craft 3 who has a deadfall shelter and a fire going. You cut it to 3. Without Craft 1+ you can endure the wilds yourself, but you cannot shepherd others through them.

The Boss's command (Heart 1+). As a Veteran you rule the melee. As a Journeyman, the journey. As a Sorcerer, the unseen. As a Boss, the company. Your Heart gives you **henchman** slots (one per Heart level), not day-rate hirelings. It also anchors whether hirelings on a delve you lead hold or break (Morale Check: 2d6 + your Heart). Henchmen who delved with you earn bonus XP from your award without costing the party. **Any delver** can hire torchbearers and sellswords for coin. Heart is what makes *henchmen* yours. See *Hirelings and retainers* and *The Boss, henchmen and command*.

Alignment

Alignment is an Approach for when the fiction does not map cleanly to Sword, Craft, Heart, or Sorcerie. It is also for a **standing** tie to something bigger than a skill. The Referee names the axis. You count every Trait across all your Approaches that bears on it, **divide by 4, round down**. That number is your **Alignment level** with that axis for this roll or this bond.

Situational Alignment is the catch-all for the odd moment. Hauled before the Thieves' Guild masters, Heart is close but not quite. The Referee calls **Alignment with the Thieves' Guild** instead, counting canting, streetwise, that season you spent as a fence. Use a fixed Approach for ordinary rolls. Reach for situational Alignment only for the particular strange thing in front of you.

Patron Alignment is the same math. The axis is an otherworldly being: a god, saint, d'jinn, dead power, or thing from beyond the veil that has a True Name and a nature. Record it on your sheet when it matters: *Lunara 2, the Voice in the Void 1*. It grows the way everything in Burners grows. You take Traits that bear on the patron at level-up. You keep a **Relic** of theirs. You accept their shaping after a pact. You do deeds they favor. A Relic of the patron (their conduit, often a named Arcana or other named item) counts as +1 Alignment with that patron for Invocations only.

Alignment level	What it means at the table
0	Stranger. The patron may not hear, or the Offer is thin.
1	Known. Small favors, one clear Ask.
2	Favored. Serious Offers; shaping sticks.
3+	Saint. Their business is yours; see [[Burners Invocations]].

Patron Alignment is **not** Sorcerie. Calling on the patron — pageantry, True Name, Offer and Ask — is an **Invocation**. The full rules live on [[Burners Invocations]].

HP, Heat, and Armor

You have HP of one d6 per character level, rolled. Just 1d6 at first level. Reroll on each level-up for the higher of the new total or the old plus one. HP is not meat. It is luck, wind, and the reflex to turn a blow — **hit protection**. Blows come off your HP as near-misses. Only overflow **past 0** opens a **Wound**, driving your HP into the negative (see *Wounds*). That overflow adds to **wound severity**. At **0** you are out of luck, not yet cut — ordinary people have no hit protection and sit at 0 without being Wounded.

Heat is the other track. It is not a pool of hit points. It is the scene's pressure, shared by your whole crew. It is the difficulty your out-of-combat costs are quoted against, and the clock that tells you how close the job is to going wrong. Every scene opens at a base (a quiet meet 3-4, a working delve or a parley that matters 6, a blown job or a hall on fire 8) and climbs as costs mount. Blows in a fight do not feed it; those go to HP. Heat rises in a fight only when the Referee judges the danger has turned. It has no ceiling. A hot scene is simply a dangerous one.

Armor is what you wear. It soaks on the way in. Its AC comes off every blow before your HP. AC runs from 1 to 5 by make: leather 1, gambeson 2, chain mail 3, plate mail and field plate 4, full plate 5. Heavy harness eats more of your twelve and leaves a thinner pool when you roll Initiative. Leather, gambeson, and mail are open. **Plate is trained-only** (see *Training* under *Weapons, Armor, and Shields*). Armor keeps you from being worn down, not from being cut once you are down. In heavy armor you lose HP slowly, but the Wound you take past 0 is raw.

Sample Traits by Approach

See *Traits* under Character Creation for the full sample lists. Short form:

- **Sword:** arms, armor, and the fight — skills like arming sword, shield, ambush, tactics; trained-only greatsword, poleax, longbow, plate armor. Qualities: strong, fearless, relentless, steady, iron-willed, veteran.
- **Craft:** lockpicking, stealth, tracking, disguise, sailing, herbalism, smithing, survival, bushcraft; **Canting** opens the Darkman's school (Craft, not Sorcerie). Qualities: nimble, observant, patient, resourceful, quiet, cunning.
- **Heart:** persuasion, intimidation, deception, leadership, empathy, trading, medicine, performance, streetwise; languages as Traits (Northmaren, Harn, Eldarin, ...). Qualities: charming, commanding, loyal, silver-tongued, well-connected.
- **Sorcerie:** qualities like perceptive, studious, second-sight, haunted; arts like divination and alchemy. Magic schools are Traits (trained-only): **Vitae**, **Elementale**, **Thaumaturgy**, **Illusione**, **Umbrakala**, **Necromantia**, and **Canting** (Craft). Common **Sorcerie** needs no Trait.

Sample Party

- **Aldric**, Sword 1 (Veteran). “Seen too much to flinch, too little to quit.”
 - 4 HP and chain mail (AC 3): every blow he takes is shaved by 3 before it reaches him, so he wears down slowly and is hard to drop. Past 0, his Wound is raw like anyone's.
 - Traits: arming sword, shield, plate armor, ambush (Sword).
 - Held: arming sword and a rotella (4 dice on the Initiative roll).
 - Signatures: none yet, a plain tough veteran waiting for a habit to harden into one.
- **Senna**, Sorcerie 1 (Sorcerer). “Reads the world like a book nobody else can open.”
 - 4 HP and leather (AC 1). With Sword 0 her defense is thin and her HP goes fast, so she survives by staying out of reach, not by soaking blows.
 - Traits: marsh-lore, second-sight, witch-blood, Vitae (Sorcerie).
 - Hand: *Read Magic*, *Healing Touch*, *Stanch*, and two other 1sts from her book — all five ready. *Stanch* is the card that helps at 0 HP or less; *Healing Touch* does not.
 - Split: 5 Arcana slots (hand size 5), 7 physical — a wand as Wizard Drip in Arcana slots, the rest plain kit.
- **Pip**, Craft 1 (Journeyman). “Has never been caught. Not once.”
 - 4 HP and leather (AC 1). Like Senna, he relies on not being hit rather than on soaking blows.
 - Traits: stealth, lockpicking, disguise, nimble (Craft).
 - Signature: Mizzle (on his stealth), slipping away unseen the moment a scene turns against him.

Signatures

Your Signature is an asterisk on the Trait it springs from: a knack that showed up at your table. You earn one per level in that Approach.

Signatures take three common shapes; the Referee may allow others:

- **Named item.** You name a weapon, shield, armor, or tool on a Trait you already hold (*arming sword* → *Naurdring*; *hunting bow* → *the fen-bow*). That name **is** the Signature: put the asterisk on the Trait. For arms and armor, see *Enchanted Arms and Armor* below.
- **Instinct.** Something you always do becomes a thing that never fails you. Back to the wall, and nothing flanks or surprises you from behind. Poke the chest with a ten-foot pole first, and its traps never catch you. The habit is the trigger; honor it in the fiction and the edge is automatic.
- **Holdout.** A small thing you keep hidden on your person: a boot knife, a flint sewn into your collar, an accelerant vial stitched into a sleeve. Name it and say where it rides. It lives outside your twelve slots and stays with you even when you are searched or stripped of gear. Out of combat it is free to reach. In a fight, drawing it costs one Fuel.

Enchanted Arms and Armor

Enchanted, legendary, eldritch, magic — same class. A module *+1 sword* is a magic sword: woken steel, not a mild bump. It may hum, light the dark, hate a quarry, or speak. The plus is how you stock it (see [[Burners Referee Magic Items]]), not how small it is.

Acceptance. The enchantment only answers someone who holds the fitting **Trait** for that kit — *arming sword*, *chain mail*, *hunting bow*, *heater*, and so on. That is not a roll. The blade accepts you or it does not. Without the Trait you may still carry and swing the steel as ordinary kit (Slots, AC, faces); the magic stays quiet — no extra die, no powers. Most war Traits sit under Sword, so Veterans usually claim the magic steel. A Journeyman with *hunting bow* can still be accepted by a magic hunting bow.

With the Trait you are accepted: **one extra die** when that item is the thing in play (Initiative pool and on the blow, Defend, or Block), and its **powers** once you have found them.

A **Named item** Signature on that Trait (your steel, named) is the same acceptance — the name marks it as yours.

Sentient blades are enchanted kit that also have a will (see [[Burners Referee Magic Items]]). They still require the Trait to accept you as a wielder; personality, jealousy, and speech sit on top of that.

See [[Burners Referee Magic Items]] for stocking and +n.

Part Two: Playing

The Two Steps

Step 1: Say What You Do

Say what you do. *I pick the lock.* Not *I try to pick the lock.*

The Referee rules one of three ways:

- If the plan is sound and fits who you are, it works. No roll.
- If it has no chance, it fails. No roll.
- If it could work but is risky, go to Step 2.

Your Theme and Traits help the Referee see that you could do it. They do not skip the roll on their own. If your Theme is a life of crime, you may just read a street. Weave a Trait into what you say so the table hears how you do it.

Step 2: Pay the Cost

A risky deed has a Cost, usually a bump of Heat. The Referee names the Cost. You roll to pay less of it.

You still do the thing. The dice say what it cost you. Where Heat does not fit, the price is time, noise, position, or a Spicy twist.

You roll when there is a price, or when the outcome is uncertain.

Approach Roll

When the Referee asks for a roll, they name the target. Name your Approach.

Roll 2d6 and add your Approach level. Meet or beat the target and you do it clean. Fall short and you pay: HP or a wound if you are in personal peril, or Heat if the trouble is on the crew.

There is no separate birthright to withstand a danger. You endure with the same four Approaches you act with. When a hazard tests you, pick the Approach the danger asks for and roll against the Referee's Cost:

- **Sword:** hold your feet, force a door, stay conscious under a wound.
- **Craft:** dodge what you cannot fight: a dart, a pit, a floor giving way, a creeping poison.
- **Heart:** hold your nerve against fear, a charm, a horror from the dark.
- **Sorcerie:** shrug off a mind-magic and dredge up what you know.

Where none fits, work it as an Alignment (see Alignment). Hostile magic in a fight uses Fuel Defend against the caster's cast total (see *Defending against a spell* under Combat and *[[Burners Sorcerie]]*).

Sweet & Spicy

Out of combat:

- One 6 or one 1 is a single twist, good or ill.
- Double Sweet (two 6s, a natural 12) is the perfect roll: the best outcome the fiction allows.
- Double Spicy (two 1s, a natural 2) is a fumble: the worst fitting outcome lands.

Combat has no Sweet or Spicy. A 6 in Fuel is a **Spark** (see Fighting).

Heat

Heat is your crew's shared danger clock, not a pool of hit points. It is the pressure of the scene. It does two jobs. It is the difficulty many out-of-combat costs are quoted against. It is also the clock that tells you how close the job is to going wrong. Blade and claw feed HP, not Heat. What feeds Heat is everything else that costs the crew.

Cost	How it lands
A narrative shortfall (a blown sneak, a hard parley)	+Heat by an amount the Referee sets, usually 1 or 2
A risky out-of-combat action	its Cost, usually a bump of Heat, which you roll to reduce
Fresh danger revealed (a threat shown, an alarm, reinforcements)	+Heat by the Referee's call, often the threat's Hit Dice

Cost	How it lands
A blow in a fight	nothing to Heat; it goes to the target's HP

Heat is the margin the whole crew shares. It climbs until the crew acts on the room to bring it down. It has no ceiling. A very hot scene is simply a very dangerous one, quoted against and escalating until you cool it or leave. There is no personal pool of Heat and no bypass. Personal harm is what HP and Wounds are for. In a fight, Heat is mostly still. It climbs only when the Referee judges the danger has turned, and often not at all. But its level still bites. Whatever the gauge stands at is added to the enemy's pool on the Initiative roll, a die per point. A hot scene simply fights back harder.

Being surprised, caught, or outmaneuvered is not a bypass. The Referee adds a situational Damage modifier and you defend as normal against the higher number.

A coup de grace finishes a helpless foe outright. A truly helpless foe (bound, asleep, or pinned and ignored), finished at leisure, is dispatched by the finishing action rather than a defend.

A shown threat sets the room. A monster's menace, shown before it strikes, is its Hit Dice. Reveal a threat and its HD become the floor of the Heat gauge, climbing in stages as the crew learns it: spoor, then half-eaten kills, then the beast itself at full HD. A pack sets the floor by summed Hit Dice, capped by chokepoints and the dark. Its presence sets the room. Its attacks still quote its own Damage (Hit Dice plus weapon) against your defense and HP. Conceal the threat instead and it raises no Heat; it strikes from surprise. Overcome or evade it and the menace vents away.

Venting Heat. The gauge falls when the crew acts on the room, not on demand. Overcome a named threat (a sentry silenced, a door barred, a beast felled) and it drops 2. Remove a named source (quench the fire, kill the lantern, learn the ward-phrase) and it drops 1, more if that source set the temperature. A Double Sweet on any roll vents 1. A word or a plan that steadies the room, if the Referee buys it, vents 1 once a scene. Folding ends the scene and cools the gauge to the next scene's base. Downtime (a safe camp or a town between jobs) returns Heat to base. A job that ended loud raises the base of what follows until the crew lies low.

Wounds

You take a **Wound** when:

- an attack drives you **below 0 HP** (overflow past 0) — steel, claw, or drain touch alike;
- or harm lands where **HP cannot help** (helpless coup, some poisons, module specials — Referee's call).

Resolve each Wound once, then carry it. Wounds accumulate. Penalties last until you reach **full HP** (maimings excepted). A blow that lands you **exactly at 0** spends the last of your luck; you are not Wounded until a blow drives you negative.

Wound severity. Keep a running total for the fight: for each attack that caused a Wound, add its **overflow** past 0 (damage that drove you below 0 after armor). Non-HP Wounds (where HP cannot help) add **0** unless that same attack also overflowed HP.

1. Find the location. Use a named spot if someone called it, or roll 1d6: 1 head, 2 torso, 3 waist, 4 arm, 5 hand, 6 leg. A limb is left or right, by the fiction or a coin, and a hit takes one limb.
2. Deepen the tally. If the blow drove you below 0, your HP goes that far negative (armor already worked on the way in). The negative tally is flesh; it accumulates. Severity for the fight rises by that overflow.
3. Apply the location effect. A vital wound leaves you up and fighting but carries a location effect. A limb wound disables that limb.
4. **Shock Check** — immediately. This asks whether you stay **combat-effective**, not whether you die.

Location effects

- **Head, reeling.** Tunnel vision. You engage and defend only what is directly in front of you, and any foe you cannot see strikes you as if you were surprised (no shield or parry against them). Mild against one foe, deadly when you are surrounded.
- **Torso, winded.** The blow knocks the wind out of you: lose one Fuel die at once. If your pool is already empty, you forfeit your next refill instead, so the hit always tells, but once, not forever.
- **Waist, collapsed.** You are in the dirt and cannot stand up until you reach **full HP**.
- **Arm or hand.** That limb is unusable. A weapon arm cannot attack; a shield or off arm cannot use a shield.
- **Leg.** You go in the dirt and cannot stand up until you reach **full HP**, the same as a waist wound.

In the dirt — see glossary (spent Fuel is re-rolled; pressed rise needs a re-rolled 3+). You can still Block from the ground. A waist or leg wound holds you down until **full HP**; you cannot rise before then. Being in the dirt does not stack, however you ended up there. A fresh, untended wound also makes that spot a soft target. A blow called at an already-wounded spot deals 2 extra damage until you reach **full HP**.

The Shock Check

Every Wound puts your footing in question. Roll **2d6 + Sword against total wound severity** this fight. Meet or beat it and you keep fighting, shaken. Fall short and the shock lands — read the raw 2d6 on the table below (worst at the bottom). Natural **1+1 always fails**; natural **6+6 always succeeds**, whatever the Cost.

2d6	Shock
2	Knocked out, and the wound bites deep: add the shortfall to your negative HP (and to severity).
3	Knocked out: down, out of the fight, senseless.
4	Knocked out: down, out of the fight, senseless.
5	Sprawled and disarmed: knocked into the dirt, and you drop what you hold.
6	Sprawled: knocked into the dirt (see <i>In the dirt</i>).
7	Stunned: you lose your next Action.
8	Winded: lose one Fuel die at once, or your next refill if your pool is empty.
9	Staggered: driven back out of reach, and a foe may step after you.
10	Disarmed: you drop what you hold.
11	Rocked: you keep your feet, shaken but still fighting.
12	Unshaken: shrug it off, and rise for free if you were already in the dirt.

If you have nothing to drop (you're unarmed or casting), the Referee swaps a disarm result for a fitting shock instead: a spell guttering out, a lost hold, a wasted breath.

Going Down

A downed ally is knocked out, not dead — until a coup de grace finishes them, or the fight ends without help (below). Win the fight and get them help.

After the fight — survival

After **any fight in which you took a Wound**, you **die** unless you receive **help** in time (an ally's Action, first aid, *Stanch*, Vitae, or other care the Referee accepts).

Helped, you make a **survival check: 2d6 + Craft vs total wound severity**. An ally who assists may let you use **their Craft** in place of yours. Natural **1+1 always fails; 6+6 always succeeds**. Fail, or go unhelped → **dead**.

Death is death. Some monsters (wights, and other drain undead) have **special rules** that kick in if you die from their attack after a Wound past 0 — rising as spawn, and so on. See the monster and [[Burners Referee Guide]].

Healing and recovery

Full HP closes wounds. Maimings at the brink do not heal on their own.

- **Hour Rest** (one hour, food and water): recover **all HP** to maximum — **only if you have no Wound**. If you are Wounded, Hour Rest does nothing for HP until you are whole again.
- **Wounded**: recover **1 HP per day** naturally (safe rest with food) until **full HP**, then the Wound closes. *Stanch*, other Vitae, potions, and surgeons can restore HP sooner; *Healing Touch* does not help at **0 HP or less** — that is *Stanch*.
- **First aid** (Craft): tends a wound in the field; it does not restore HP by itself, but can be the **help** that lets you attempt the survival check.

Example. Aldric (Sword 1, maximum 4 HP) is driven to -3 by a blow of overflow 3: Wound, severity 3, leg — in the dirt. Shock (2d6 + Sword vs 3) beats it; he stays effective but in the dirt. After the fight an ally helps; survival (2d6 + Craft vs 3) succeeds. He climbs 1 HP per day (-2, -1, 0, 1...) until full 4; then the Wound closes. Hour Rest would not have filled him while Wounded.

The danger is the Wound. Every one is a Shock Check in the fight and a survival check after. Cover downed friends. Reach full HP and you are whole again.

The crew fights an ogre in a working scene. Heat at 6. Aldric (Sword 1, 4 HP, chain mail AC 3, arming sword, rotella) rolls Initiative for seven dice. His twelve are full (mail 6, sword 2, shield 4), so no empty-slot dice. Two for the sword, four for the shield, one for his level: 6, 5, 4, 3, 2, 2, 1. Three show 3 or 4, so his Initiative is 3. The Referee locks order; Aldric beats the ogre's count and acts first. On his turn a Veteran gets two attacks. With a one-handed sword (2 slots) each is a single die, so he spends the 5 and the 3 for blows of 5 and 3. Eight into the ogre. No 6 among them, so no Spark. He has meleed this round, so when the ogre's great club comes — three dice for a blow worth 10 — Aldric Defends without limit. He spends the 6 and the 4 to cut all 10. His chain mail is never tested. Order stays locked even though he spent a 4. Fuel left: 2, 2, 1, plus the refill the next Roll Initiative brings. Next round they Roll Initiative — refill one die for his level — and lock order again. The ogre swings for 10 again. Aldric spends his 2, 2, 1 and the refill to cut 8. His chain mail soaks the rest, so nothing lands, but his hand is now empty. The round after, winded, the blow arrives whole: 10 less 3 for chain mail is 7. With 4 HP he is driven to -3 — a Wound (severity 3), leg, in the dirt. Shock (2d6 + Sword vs 3) beats it, so he stays effective in the dirt, but his dice are gone. Finish it or fold — and get him help when it ends.

When you face control magic, you **Defend** the same way you defend a blow, but a clean overrun lands the effect (stun, hold, charm, sleep), not HP damage. See *Defending against a spell* in [[Burners Sorcerie]].

Fighting

Each Combat Round is one minute. You act in locked Initiative order. On your turn you get one Action: attack, cast, or feat. Moving, readying, taking cover, or aiming come with it, part of the same Action rather than a turn of their own. Only a demanding shift (rising from the ground, or breaking away under threat) costs you the Action itself. Defending is not free. You spend Fuel whenever you are struck.

Rolling Initiative. Say **Roll Initiative** at the top of every round. There is no separate surprise rule. You fight with what you were actually carrying.

Round 1. Gather a pool of d6s for what you hold right now:

- one die per character level;
- one die per slot if you have a weapon in hand;
- one die per slot if you have a shield in hand;
- one die per empty inventory slot, up to 4;
- one die per Arcana slot. (Empty or full. Do not double-count empty Arcana slots.)

Roll them all. The faces you rolled, kept as they lie, are your Fuel for the fight. Your Initiative is the count of them showing 3 or 4. The Referee locks order for the round — highest first. Ties: PCs win; among PCs the players choose who goes first; a PC tied with a foe may act first or yield.

Round 2 and after. Roll Initiative means refill: add one Fuel die per character level, roll those into your pool at once, then count 3s and 4s across the whole pool (held faces plus the new dice). The Referee locks order for the round again. The first round brings no refill; that opening roll is your wind. Spending a 3 or 4 during the round does not change the locked order — only the next Roll Initiative does.

If you empty your hand on offense you are caught winded until the next Roll Initiative's refill, blows arriving whole in the meantime. Spend with that in mind. Fuel you are forced to lose but cannot pay from your pool comes out of your next refill instead. Such a cost always lands, exactly once, and never leaves you owing a debt you cannot pay.

Burning Fuel. Everything you do in combat burns Fuel. You must spend Fuel to attack, defend, cast, and so on. A die is used at its face and discarded. No reroll. The pool you play is the faces you rolled.

Sparks. A natural 6 in your Fuel is a **Spark**. Play it (the 6 is spent) and it entitles you to a second combat action this turn, beyond your one Action: an attack, a Block, or a Stunt. A Spark played while defending buys an immediate counterattack, a **Riposte**. The Spark grants only the opening. You still pay for that second action from your Fuel like any other. Roll several 6s and you may play several Sparks.

Attacking. You make one attack a round (as a Veteran you make more; see below). It costs one Fuel die, and its face is the damage. A weapon of **3+ slots wielded in two hands** can add a second die. Up to two dice a blow from mundane steel, all paid from your Fuel, their faces together the damage. From that, subtract the target's soak: a Burner's **armor AC**, or a monster's **Resistance** if any (monsters have no AC — see [[Burners Referee Guide]]). The rest comes off their HP. Past 0 the overflow is a Wound. Because armor soaks every blow on the way in, a flurry of small hits is how you cut down an unarmored Burner; heavier steel cracks plated kit. Hunting bows and other 2-slot arms stay one die. Roll a 6 and you may play it as a **Spark** (above) for a second attack, Block, or Stunt.

Veteran Attacks. As a Veteran you strike more than once: one extra attack per Sword level. At Sword 1 you make two. At Sword 3 you make four. Each is its own blow of its own dice, all inside your single Attack action. Each may fall on the same foe or spread across several. Any of these attacks may instead be spent to **Block** or on a **Stunt** (below) rather than to strike. With several attacks you can Block for the crew, or trip and disarm, as readily as you deal damage.

Defending. There is no defense roll. Blows land. When struck, spend Fuel dice and cut the incoming Damage by their faces. Your armor soaks the rest, and what remains comes off your HP. Caps: **melee** — one die, or no limit if you made a melee attack this round (any foe); **missile** — one die, or two if you have Cover; **hostile magic** — no limit. While **in the dirt**, same caps — but every die you spend is re-rolled. Roll a 6 while defending and you may play it as a Spark for a **Riposte**: an immediate counterattack (except as under Cover). If you're the archer or mage caught in reach without having meleed, you cut each melee blow with a single die.

Example — dirty fighting. Aldric's Fuel is a ruin: 2, 2, 1, 1. The ogre's club is coming for 10 and he has already meleed, so he may Defend without limit — but those faces will not cut it. He throws himself in the dirt (free with what's left of the exchange). He dumps all four dice into the Defend; each re-rolls: 5, 4, 6, 1 = 16. Club stopped, and the 6 is a Spark for a Riposte from the dirt. Cinema. Next he still has to rise under the press — a die re-rolled 3+ — or keep scrambling in the dirt.

Cover. Fiction that lets you spend two dice vs a missile (wall, raised shield, creature...). Using a melee foe as Cover: if you Spark on that Defend, the shot hits them instead of Riposting. The blow never touches their Fuel or AC until it redirects.

Block. Spend an attack to interpose yourself between an adjacent ally and a threat attacking that ally. The blow redirects onto you; Defend it normally — before they spend Fuel or soak with their AC. One attack covers one blow.

Stunts. A **Stunt** is what you do with an attack instead of dealing damage or Blocking: a knockdown, a shove, a disarm, a trip, a grapple, a feint that pins a foe in place. You spend an attack as you would to strike, and its dice are the force behind it. The target may resist by Defending as against a blow. Where there is no real contest, the Referee simply rules it. Size is the fiction the Referee weighs. A foe your own size or smaller is a fair contest. One size up (you wrestling an ogre alone) is a hard sell that wants a tool, a trap, or numbers. Two sizes up (you against a giant) simply cannot be toppled by one body. You need a tool, a trap, or the crowd. A braced or many-legged base counts a size larger, and it cuts both ways when something bigger grabs at you. Disarm turns on grip, not mass, so size does not apply. Spend the attack and lose the contest and it is gone for nothing. A botched grab at something far larger, the Referee may turn against you. Any attack can be a Stunt. You spend one of your several on it as a Veteran, or a Spark buys one. You can end a fight by taking a foe off their feet or their sword out of their hand, not only by cutting them down.

A Stunt that leaves a lasting state (in the dirt, disarmed, grappled) is what gives it teeth. The state itself is the price. **In the dirt** — spent Fuel is re-rolled; rising under a press needs a re-rolled 3+ (see *In the dirt*). Disarmed, you have no weapon. Shaking it off is part of your action and free when nothing presses you. Under a foe's steel, pay as the state demands (in the dirt: a re-rolled 3+, or a die for other recoveries). (No die to spare? It comes out of your next refill, so it always lands.) A Stunt does not spend a foe's HP. It strips their guard or their weapon. If your side keeps them pressed it grinds recovery from them. They may instead pay nothing and fight from the state — swinging bare-handed, or Defending with re-rolled Fuel — until a turn they would rather spend the die shaking it. The choice of which hurts less is theirs.

Range and reach buy safety. A far arrow risks nothing until the enemy closes, so soften foes at a distance and fear the melee. Damage and a foe's defense belong to the situation. A shield wall is tougher from the front. A swarm combines into one bigger threat that thins as you kill it. A chokepoint caps how many reach you. Narrate the cause, so you can attack the reason.

Armor

Armor is what you wear; its AC comes off every blow before HP.

- Leather, gambeson, and mail. AC by make: leather 1, gambeson 2, chain mail 3, plate mail and field plate 4, full plate 5.
- Leather, gambeson, and mail are open. **Plate** (plate mail and above) is trained-only: see *Training* under *Weapons, Armor, and Shields*. Heavy armor eats into your twelve. If you armor up you carry and move with little to spare. If you travel light you keep your slots for gear and for a fatter pool when you roll Initiative.
- Armor is one number in ordinary play, with no hit locations.
- A shield is not armor; you hold it, not wear it. Its slots are dice it lends on your Initiative roll (buckler 2, heater 3, tower 5), like any held steel. A raised shield can count as **Cover** vs missiles (2 dice on that Defend). **Block** redirects a blow onto you; the shield does not deepen it.

We Burn Undead

In the Dragon Isles there is no priest who lifts a holy symbol and sends the skeletons scattering. You don't turn undead. You burn undead. The dead are dry: old bone, grave-linen, tomb-dust, the leathered husk of a thing that stopped drinking centuries ago. Nothing takes a torch more gladly. When you meet the walking dead, the plan is rarely subtle. Light the barrow, and stand back.

The mindless dead: steel fails, fire feasts. The shambling horde (skeletons, corpse-things, grave-risen) are monsters with HP, built like any other, with one convention that makes the fiction true:

- **Resistance to blades.** A sword through a skeleton finds no organs, no blood, no lungs to collapse. Steel does little (treat undead as having Resistance against cutting and piercing weapons; the Referee sets the value by how bony or desiccated the thing is). Bludgeoning that shatters rather than cuts ignores this. A mace or maul works where slicing does not.
- **Vulnerability to fire.** The dead are kindling. Fire ignores their blade-Resistance and bites deep. A torch, a flask of oil, a stray flame: count fire damage at full, or with a bonus, the Referee's call. Burning is the right play, not color.

So the answer to a crypt full of the shuffling dead is not a magic word. It is oil, flame, and a fast exit. Bring more oil than you think you need. You will use it.

The willful dead: the deal, not the torch. The mighty dead are a different problem. A wraith has no dry flesh to catch. A lich keeps its life hidden in a phylactery the fire never touches. A vampire lord has laughed at torches for a thousand years. Fire alone will not clear them. Against the willful dead you need one of the rarer answers:

- **A Saint's patron.** If you have dealt with an otherworldly being whose nature opposes the grave (see [[Burners Invocations]]), you may turn that being's power on the dead: not your holiness, but the patron's, lent through your pact. Rebuking a lich in another thing's name is the Dragon Isles' true "turning," and it costs what all pacts cost.
- **A named or eldritch edge.** A woken enchanted weapon, a Relic, a Named blade. Recall how the Kalla demon fell to the named Alu sickles. What the fire cannot burn, the right eldritch steel can cut.
- **Nerve.** As a Boss you may face down the intelligent dead by sheer presence: cow a wraith, stare down a vampire's thrall. A skeleton has no will to break; a thinking dead thing does.

So: torch the horde; deal, name, or dare the lord.

"We don't turn undead. We burn undead." — the old barrow wisdom, and more oil than sense.

Defending against Damage

There is no defense roll to fail; when struck you commit dice from your Fuel and your armor soaks the rest (see Fighting). Soften foes at range, strike hard, and break off before your dice run out.

Defending against a spell. Hostile magic uses Fuel Defend against the caster's **cast total**, the same way you cut a blow. Full procedure: *Defending against a spell* in [[Burners Sorcerie]].

Magic

Magic is prepared, not spontaneous. Spells are **cards**: your spellbook is the deck, your **hand** is what you can cast now, and your **Arcana slot count** sets hand size. Arcana slots hold **Wizard Drip** (or a Canting rogue's kicks), not cards — the hand is personal. **Cast** taps a card; **burn** exiles ready cards in the same Action to recast or copy. After 8 hours' sleep you recover up to Sorcerie Level cards (Craft Level for Canting) from

tapped/burned/lasting. **Scrolls** are single-use items (physical or Arcana slot), not cards — cast and spent; hand untouched. **Potions** are downtime brew in a **physical** slot; anyone may drink. Hostile magic is Defended like steel.

Magic touches your game in two places. The Sorcerer title (Sorcerie 1) lets you cast. Your combat cast is one Action that spends at least L Fuel dice (L = the spell's level) and rolls them for the cast total. The spell catalog is [[Burners Spells]].

The full rules are on [[**Burners Sorcerie**]]. The catalog is [[**Burners Spells**]]. You need them if you are a Sorcerer (or a Journeyman on the Canting road). At the table you need how a spell hits you (*Defending against a spell*, under Combat).

Relics and sentient items

Relics and **sentient items** are covered on [[Burners Invocations]] (Alignment with a patron, Relic +1, true names). They are not spells; they interact with Signatures and legendary items as the Referee defines. Spell magic remains [[Burners Sorcerie]] / [[Burners Spells]].

Lingering Costs: Poison, Petrification, Paralysis

When you endure cleanly you avoid the bite: the fitting Approach against its Cost, Craft against poison (see *Approach Roll*). Once it lands, it deals its level in damage to your HP each round for a number of rounds equal to its level, with no further defense. You escape it with a cure (an antidote, a Vitae working) or by surviving the duration. Past 0 HP it wounds you each round, deepening your negative tally like any wound, or petrifies or paralyzes you as the effect dictates. The Referee rolls nothing. The dread does the work.

Area Effects

Counter a monster breath by raising your shield (a legendary shield is broad), by **Warding** magical breath (Sorcerer Fuel cut, then each ally Defends), by cover, or by resistance. A **spell** area effect uses **Defend** and overrun like any other hostile working (see *Defending against a spell* in [[Burners Sorcerie]]).

Influence

Say what you do and the Referee rules whether it can work (see *The Two Steps*). Ask the jailer to free the prisoners against his duty and it fails. Bribe him to look away and it works — gold or a Spicy twist, and a sharp read softens what you pay. Turn the cultists on each other only after you have built the wedge; then the room tips.

Disposition is a fact of the world. When the fiction has not fixed it, the Referee may roll the Reaction table (see [[Burners Referee Guide]]). Heart amplifies a success the fiction already grants. What you pay in coin, favor, time, or reputation is open to haggling.

Hirelings and retainers

Torchbearers, linkboys, porters, sellswords: someone has to hold the light. Any delver with coin can hire them: a daily fee, a half-share of the haul, and the hope they do not bolt when it gets ugly.

A **hireling** (or **retainer**) is someone you hire for coin: a torchbearer, a linkboy, a guide, a porter, a dockside sellsword. They are not Burners. Ordinary folk (Sword 0, untrained: a thin Fuel pool, no Veteran tricks) and usually the first to die. Bring bodies anyway. Someone has to hold the torch.

Finding and paying. You find hirelings in the fiction: a tavern notice, a dockside crew, a debt called in. The offer is a Reaction roll (see [[Burners Referee Guide]]). If you have Heart, add it to the roll. A generous purse eases it; a bad name hardens it. A delver wants a guaranteed fee *and* a share of the take. Pay the weekly rate on [[Burners Equipment#Hirelings]] (torchbearer 2 gp/week, sellsword 5, and so on) and at least a half-share of whatever you haul out. If you short the split, soon no one will sign on. Taking a hireling into a dungeon may raise the ask. Food, lodging, and new gear are on you. **Paid hirelings earn no XP.**

When the moment breaks their nerve, the Referee plays it by fiction or calls **2d6 vs the danger** with no modifier, unless a Boss on the delve is anchoring them (see below).

Keep it lean

Run hirelings as simple Sword-0 NPCs. Do not run loyalty scores unless you want to.

The fuller company

Everything above is enough for you to play. What follows is texture if you want to run a real retinue.

Types. You define each hireling by one Trait naming their job (torchbearer, porter, guide, spearman, houndmaster) and the tools of that trade in their slots. An unusually good one has a Signature or a second Trait: a veteran sellsword's shield-wall, a guide who knows the old roads. They fight as Sword-0 NPCs, rolling a thin Fuel with no Veteran tricks and monster-style low HP. Armor still soaks for them on the way in, as it does for you. Common hands: pack-bearers and linkboys (carry loads, hold light); spearmen and sellswords (a weapon and a little armor); shield-bearers (resupply your broken shields); squires (ready your weapons, help you don armor); war-dogs (a bite and a thick hide).

Mercenaries, the garrison. Mercenaries are soldiers-for-hire, not companions. They hold a wall, guard a camp, or march with an army, but they will not descend into a barrow. Post notices and hire by the month; food and basic kit are included in the rate, and every wage doubles in wartime.

Troop	gp / month	Troop	gp / month
Peasant levy	1	Archer	5
Light footman	2	Light horseman / longbowman	10
Heavy footman	3	Medium horseman / mounted archer	15
Crossbowman	4	Heavy horseman	20

Their Morale is their own score: 6 for a peasant levy up to 9 for mounted troops, checked on 2d6. If a Boss is on the field, they can steady them the same way they steady delving hirelings.

The Boss, henchmen and command (Heart 1+)

*As a Veteran you rule the melee, as a Journeyman the journey, as a Sorcerer the unseen, and as a Boss you rule the company. Heart is presence, command, and the strange gravity that makes frightened people follow you into a barrow they'd never enter alone. **Anyone can hire hands for coin:** Heart is what gives you **henchmen** who grow with you, and the nerve to keep a company together when the dark turns ugly.*

Boss is only the mechanical name for Heart 1+. Rename it to fit your character, and your people will address you by that title: Captain, Chief, Coven-Mother, Ser or Dame, Boss. Pick the word your company calls you. The rules are the same under any of them.

Henchmen

A **henchman** is not a day-rate hireling. They are *your* sworn companion: keep, a half-share of treasure, and the bond that lets them grow with you. Only a **Boss (Heart 1+)** may have henchmen. Any delver can hire a torchbearer; only a Boss fills a **henchman slot**.

Slots. You have one henchman slot per **Heart level**. A starting Boss (Heart 1) begins with **one slot filled**: the henchman from starting gear. Each time your Heart rises, you gain an empty slot. Fill it in play by nurturing a relationship with an NPC: a hireling who stayed when it mattered, a guide you kept your word to, a sellsword you pulled out of the barrow. The Referee decides when the bond is real. Not a Reaction roll on day one, but earned trust.

On the delve. Henchmen who come with you into the dark count against your **Handling** budget when you lead the company (see below) and receive your Morale Check when the moment breaks. They want a daily fee or keep *and* at least a half-share of treasure recovered.

XP, the Heart benefit. When the crew earns XP, figure **your** award first (your share of monsters slain and treasure banked). Each henchman who **delved with you and survived** splits **half of your award** as **bonus XP**: not taken from you, not taken from the other PCs. One henchman present: they gain 50% of what you gained. Two henchmen present: they split that half (25% of your award each). Track their total on a margin line; it feeds advancement on the trainee path below.

Replacing a henchman. A slot emptied by death or departure stays empty until you fill it through play. Word of how you treat henchmen travels; abuse the bond and filling the next slot gets harder.

Leading the company

When **you** lead the delve, your Heart sets how many bodies you can wrangle and whether they hold.

Handling: how many will follow. Each hireling or henchman in the company you lead has a **Handling** of 1 to 4. A docile torchbearer is 1. A surly sellsword is 4. Your **Heart level caps the company's total Handling**, not raw bodies. With Heart 3 you might lead three meek porters (1+1+1), or one steady sword (2) and a linkboy (1), or two henchmen (2+2) if you have the slots. The Referee sets Handling the first time someone meets real pressure. Settled henchmen may lower it. If no Boss is leading the delve, there is no Handling cap. Hire who you can pay and the fiction supports.

Nerve: whether they hold or run. Whenever the company faces something that would break ordinary resolve (a fight turning against them, a horror rising from the crypt, a comrade cut down, wages long overdue), the Referee calls a Morale Check for the affected hirelings:

Morale Check: roll **2d6 + your Heart** against the moment's danger. The Referee sets the number, as for any check. A routine scare is low. A wraith clawing free of its tomb is high.

- **Meet or beat → they hold.** Your presence steadies them. They stay in the fight, keep the torch high, do the job.
- **Fall short → they break.** They flee, freeze, drop the torch and bolt, or throw down their tools and demand to leave. The Referee plays the failure by fiction.

Leading from the front, sharing the risk, and keeping your word all give the Referee reason to ease the check; treating hirelings as arrow-fodder gives reason to harden it (word gets around, and so does the price of your recruits).

Keep it lean

That's the Heart benefit: **henchman** slots and bonus XP; **Handling** and **Morale** when you lead the company. Run henchmen as Sword-0 NPCs with a margin-line XP total. Paid hirelings need no sheet unless you want one.

From henchman to Burner. A henchman whose XP total would reach the next character level on the table (at half your pace, they lag naturally) may be promoted to a **trainee adventurer**. They shed Handling, begin earning Traits and Signatures, and climb toward a full Burner build. When your character dies, you may take a trainee as your new Burner. The Referee may also field the rare professional adventurer: a full PC-built NPC with their own goals. These are uncommon. Nearly everyone with a real sheet is a player at the table.

You don't give your strength away. You make others braver than they have any right to be, and lead them somewhere they'll probably regret.